institutional, and bureaucratic spectrum. While some of them advocate broad-based engagement with different Afghan factions, others advocate partisan engagement. It is possible that the same official adopts different approaches—conciliatory or partisan—at different times depending on context. So it would be incorrect to use these conceptual policy denominators as a measure of 'political identity'. Nonetheless, it is possible to identify officials who actively or passively advocated one of the two approaches towards Afghanistan. In this book, which is chronologically sequenced, the ACF allows to identify the partisans and the conciliators and how they influenced India's Afghanistan policy.

Note on definitions

Terms such as partisans, conciliators, engagement, and anti-engagement, may mean different things to different readers and policy practitioners. In this book they have been used liberally throughout, but with very specific intent. The Oxford English Dictionary, for instance, defines conciliator as 'a person who acts as a mediator between two disputing people or groups'.[26] A partisan, however, is someone who is 'a strong supporter of a party, cause, or person'.[27] Both these terms have been used with similar intent. However, a conciliator in this book may not always necessarily mean someone who is actively 'conciliating' between two fighting parties (even though many Indian diplomats have done that on numerous occasions in Afghanistan). Someone who adopts a conciliatory tone towards Afghanistan is also a conciliator, regardless of whether she or he is actually able to implement such an approach in practice. Similarly, a partisan may not always mean a person who has party-political or ideological affiliations. Any Indian policymaker advocating policies towards Afghanistan by necessarily treating Pakistan as an enemy, or is not accommodative of Pakistani interests in Afghanistan, is a partisan.

Apart from partisans and conciliators, the term 'engagement' is understood as a process whereby two political entities are involved in non-coercive diplomacy and have existing channels of interaction, either covert or overt. Engagement here does not necessarily imply diplomatic recognition of the entity being engaged with. Nor does it imply imparting legitimacy to the ideas propounded and